

Chapter 13

Physical Assessment

Lesson 13.1: Disease

1. Discuss the difference between a sign and a symptom.
2. Compare and contrast the origins of disease.
3. List the four major risk categories for development of disease.
4. Discuss frequently noted signs and symptoms of disease conditions.
5. List the cardinal signs of inflammation and infection.
6. Describe the nursing responsibilities when assisting a physician with the physical examination.
7. List equipment and supplies necessary for the physical examination/assessment.

Signs and Symptoms

● Signs

- Objective data as perceived by the examiner
- Can be seen, heard, and measured and can be verified by more than one person
- Examples: rashes, altered vital signs, abnormal lung or heart sounds, and visible drainage or exudate
- Lab results, diagnostic imaging, and other studies

● Symptoms

- Subjective data
- Perceived by the patient
- Examples: pain, nausea, vertigo, and anxiety
- Nurse unaware of symptoms unless the patient describes the sensation

Disease and Diagnosis

● Disease

- It is any disturbance of a structure or function of the body; a pathologic condition of the body
- It is recognized by a set of signs and symptoms
- Signs and symptoms are clustered in groups to help the health care provider to make a medical diagnosis

● Origins of disease

- Disease or illness originates from many causes: hereditary, congenital, inflammatory, degenerative, infectious, deficiency, metabolic, neoplastic, traumatic, and environmental
- Unknown etiology
 - Diseases that have no apparent cause

Risk Factors for Development of Disease

- A *risk factor* is any situation, habit, environmental condition, genetic predisposition, physiologic condition, or other that increases the vulnerability of an individual or a group to illness or accident
- Risk factors do not necessarily mean that a person will develop a disease condition, only that the chances of disease are increased
- Categories of risk factors
 - Genetic and physiologic, age, environment, and lifestyle

Terms Used to Describe Disease

- Chronic
- Remission
- Acute
- Organic disease
- Functional disease

Inflammation and Infection

● Infection

- Caused by an invasion of microorganisms, such as bacteria, viruses, fungi, or parasites that produce tissue damage

● Inflammation

- Protective response of the body tissues of irritation, injury, or invasion by disease-producing organisms

● Cardinal signs

- Erythema, edema, heat, pain, purulent drainage, and loss of function

Assessment

- An evaluation or appraisal of the patient's condition
- Medical assessment
 - Physical examination is conducted by the health care provider
 - The nurse is often expected to carry out certain functions

Nursing Responsibilities

- Preparing the examining room
- Assisting with equipment
- Preparing the patient
- Collecting specimens

Equipment and Supplies

- Equipment and supplies include (among others):
 - Cotton applicators
 - Eye chart
 - Gloves
 - Otoscope
 - Percussion hammer
 - Scale with height measurement rod
 - Specimen containers
 - Stethoscopes
 - Thermometer

Lesson 13.2: Physical Assessment

8. Explain the necessary skills for the physical examination/nursing assessment.
9. Discuss the nurse-patient interview.
10. List the basic essentials for a patient's health history.
11. Discuss the sequence of steps when performing a nursing assessment.
12. Discuss normal and abnormal assessment findings in the head-to-toe assessment.
13. Describe documentation of the physical examination/ nursing assessment.
14. Explain ways to develop cultural sensitivity.

Initiating the Nurse-Patient Relationship

- The first interview is the most challenging to conduct
- Introduce yourself and state name, position, and purpose of the interview
- Give an estimate of time
- Ask if the patient has any questions and answer them appropriately
- Communicate trust and confidentiality
- Convey professionalism

The Interview

- Conduct in a quiet, private, well-lighted setting
- Convey feelings of compassion and concern
- Determine by what name the patient wishes to be addressed
- Nurse should have a calm demeanor, sit at eye level with patient, and pleasant facial expression

Nursing Health History

(Slide 1 of 2)

- The initial step in assessment process
- Information on patient's wellness, changes in life patterns, sociocultural role, and mental and emotional reaction to illness
- Biographic data
- Reasons for seeking health care
 - Chief complaint
- Present illness or health concerns
- Past health history

Nursing Health History

(Slide 2 of 2)

- Family history
- Environmental history
- Psychosocial and cultural history
- Review of systems

Nursing Physical Assessment

- The purpose is to determine the patient's state of health or illness
- Initial step of the nursing process and in forming the nursing care plan
- When to perform a physical assessment
 - Perform assessment as soon after admission as possible
 - Initial assessment is done by an RN
 - Ongoing assessment is the responsibility of LPN and RN
- Methods of nursing physical assessment

Head-to-Toe Assessment

- Neurologic
- Skin and hair
- Head and neck
- Mouth and throat
- Eyes, ears, and nose
- Chest, lungs, heart, and vascular system
- Gastrointestinal system
- Genitourinary system
- Rectum
- Legs and feet

Documentation

- Most institutions have a designated flowsheet in the electronic medical record or a standardized form to follow
 - Baseline for evaluation
- Be objective, clear, complete, and concise

Telephone Consultation

- It is essential to follow Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) guidelines
- Used in a variety of health care settings

Cultural Considerations

- Culture includes knowledge, skills, art, morals, law, customs, and any other acquired habits and capabilities of a group of people
- Ways to develop cultural and ethnic sensitivity
 - Recognize that cultural and ethnic diversity exist
 - Demonstrate respect for people as individuals
 - Respect the unfamiliar
 - Do not expect all members of one cultural group to behave in the same manner